VENVLEARNING

TEACHER EDITION



Social Studies

GRADE 7

Guided lessons, pacing, and complete answer keys

2026–2027 School Year · Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

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Grade 7 Social Studies

TEACHER EDITION

2026–2027 School Year

Unit 1 Early Humans and Mesopotamia

A VenvLearning family homeschool curriculum

How to use this Teacher Edition

This book holds everything needed to teach the course: unit overviews, a plan for every lesson with what to say and do, the student lesson with Try It answers, and answer keys for every workbook page, weekly check and unit test.

- Daily routine (about 45–55 minutes): Warm-Up 5 · Read and Discuss 15 · Analyze 10 · Guided Practice 7 · Independent 10 · Exit Ticket 3.
- Say: lines are a suggested script. Use your own words.
- Tuesday and Thursday are lessons. Friday is the Weekly Check (about 15 minutes), then corrections or a project.
- Dates match the VenvLearning lesson plans for the 2026–2027 school year.

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UNIT 1 · TEACHER OVERVIEW

Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Historians' tools, early humans, the Agricultural Revolution, the first cities, Sumer, writing, and the first empires and laws.

Ten thousand years ago, nearly everyone on Earth lived by hunting and gathering. Then, in a few river valleys, people began to farm, settle, and build cities. In this unit you'll learn how historians uncover the distant past, then follow humans from the Old Stone Age to Sumer, where people built the first cities, invented writing, and carved laws in stone.

Big ideas

- Use primary and secondary sources and read BCE/CE timelines.
- Explain how the Agricultural Revolution changed human life.
- Analyze how Mesopotamia's geography shaped civilization.
- Describe Sumerian society, writing, and the first empires and laws.

Standards

Code	Standard
C3 D2.His.1, 2, 9, 10	Historical context; change and continuity; sources and their limitations.
C3 D2.Geo.2, 4	Maps; human–environment interaction.
C3 D2.Civ.3	Origins and purposes of laws.

What students should already know

- Basic map skills.
- Timelines.

Materials for the unit

- Box of everyday objects
- Pan, soil, water

- Clay or play dough
- Dried beans
- World map or atlas

Pacing calendar

Week	Day	Lesson	Title
Week of Oct 26	Tue 10/27	1.1	How Historians Know the Past
Week of Oct 26	Thu 10/29	1.2	Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers
Week of Oct 26	Fri 10/30	Check	Weekly Check 1: Historians and Early Humans
Week of Nov 2	Tue 11/3	1.3	The Agricultural Revolution
Week of Nov 2	Thu 11/5	1.4	From Villages to Civilizations
Week of Nov 2	Fri 11/6	Check	Weekly Check 2: Farming and Civilization
Week of Nov 9	Tue 11/10	1.5	Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers
Week of Nov 9	Thu 11/12	1.6	Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society
Week of Nov 9	Fri 11/13	Check	Weekly Check 3: Mesopotamia and Sumer
Week of Nov 16	Tue 11/17	1.7	Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing
Week of Nov 16	Thu 11/19	1.8	Empires and the Code of Hammurabi
Week of Nov 16	Fri 11/20	Test	Unit 1 Test

TEACHING THIS UNIT AT HOME

Look at a clock and a compass together and talk about how the Sumerian base-60 system still shapes how we measure time and angles.

UNIT VOCABULARY

primary source	Created at the time by a participant.
Agricultural Revolution	The shift to farming.
civilization	A complex society with cities and government.
irrigation	Bringing water to crops.
cuneiform	Sumerian wedge-shaped writing.
empire	Many lands under one ruler.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.1 · C3 D2.His.9.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8 · Tue Oct 27

Lesson 1.1: How Historians Know the Past

I can distinguish primary and secondary sources, explain how archaeologists learn about the past, and read a BCE/CE timeline.

Objective	Students classify sources and read BCE/CE timelines.
Standard	C3 D2.His.9.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8 — Classify sources; detect limitations of the historical record.
Date	Tue Oct 27
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Box of everyday objects, workbook Lesson 1.1
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	Bedroom in 5,000 years.
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson.
Analyze	10	Model source questions. Model counting across BCE/CE.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook lesson pages: Warm-Up through Exit Ticket.
Exit Ticket	3	Student completes the Exit Ticket alone. Check it before the next lesson.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Treating BCE dates like CE (thinking larger numbers are later).

SUPPORT

- Number line with BCE to the left.

EXTEND

- Interview a grandparent: an oral history is a primary source.

STUDENT LESSON 1.1 · WITH ANSWERS

Lesson 1.1: How Historians Know the Past

THINK ABOUT IT

Imagine someone in 5,000 years digs up your bedroom. What would your things tell them about you, and what would they get wrong?

Historians are detectives. They gather evidence from primary sources (letters, laws, inscriptions, photographs, artifacts) and secondary sources (textbooks, articles, documentaries). For times before writing, archaeologists study artifacts, bones, seeds, and buildings. Scientists can estimate the age of once-living material using radiocarbon dating.

Every source has limits. A king's inscription may brag. Artifacts made of stone and clay survive, but cloth, wood, and memories usually don't. Good historians ask: Who made this? When? Why? What might be missing?

Dates before year 1 are written BCE and count down toward year 1: 3000 BCE is earlier than 2000 BCE. Dates after are CE and count up. There is no year 0.



LOOK CLOSER · COUNT ACROSS THE BCE/CE LINE

How many years passed between 500 BCE and 500 CE?

1. From 500 BCE to 1 BCE is 499 years; then 1 BCE to 1 CE is 1 year.
2. From 1 CE to 500 CE is 499 years.
3. 499 + 1 + 499 = 999.

Answer: 999 years (because there is no year 0).

ACTIVITY · TIME CAPSULE DETECTIVES

What can objects tell us, and what can't they?

You need: a box of 6–8 everyday objects chosen by your teacher (receipt, toy, coin, photo, tool, food wrapper).

1. Examine each object as if you were an archaeologist in the year 7026.
2. For each, write one inference about the people who used it.
3. Sort the objects into primary sources and secondary sources (if any).
4. Write what these objects can't tell you about the family.

Record: an evidence chart: Object | What it suggests | Questions it raises.

KEY IDEA

Historians use primary and secondary sources, ask who made a source and why, and recognize that evidence is always incomplete.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. Primary or secondary: a clay tablet written in 2000 BCE

Answer: primary

2. Primary or secondary: a website about ancient Sumer

Answer: secondary

3. Which is earlier, 2500 BCE or 1800 BCE?

Answer: 2500 BCE

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.1.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.1

#	Question	Answer
1	An object made by people long ago	artifact
2	A source made by an eyewitness	primary source
3	Primary or secondary: a diary from 1863	primary
4	Primary or secondary: your history textbook	secondary
5	Primary or secondary: a stone tool	primary (artifact)
6	Order from earliest: 1200 BCE, 3500 BCE, 200 CE, 500 BCE	3500 BCE, 1200 BCE, 500 BCE, 200 CE
7	Years from 3000 BCE to 1000 BCE	2,000 years
8	Years from 200 BCE to 300 CE	499 years
9	A king's victory monument says he never lost a battle. Why should a historian be careful with this source?	It was made to praise the king, so it may exaggerate or leave out defeats.
10	Name one strength and one limit of using artifacts as evidence.	Strength: real objects from the time. Limit: only durable items survive; they don't explain thoughts or events.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.2 · C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Geo.6.6-8 · Thu Oct 29

Lesson 1.2: Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers

I can describe how early humans lived as hunter-gatherers and spread across the world.

Objective	Students describe Paleolithic life and migration.
Standard	C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Geo.6.6-8 — Analyze connections among events; explain how humans spread.
Date	Thu Oct 29
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Workbook Lesson 1.2
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	No stores or farms.
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson.
Analyze	10	Discuss needs chart; evidence for early life.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook. Weekly Check Friday.
Exit Ticket	3	Student completes the Exit Ticket alone. Check it before the next lesson.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Picturing “cavemen” as unintelligent.

SUPPORT

- Picture walk of artifacts.

EXTEND

- Research the Lascaux cave paintings.

STUDENT LESSON 1.2 · WITH ANSWERS

Lesson 1.2: Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers

THINK ABOUT IT

If you had no stores, farms, or metal tools, how would you get food and stay warm?

Fossils show that our species, Homo sapiens, appeared in Africa roughly 300,000 years ago. Over many thousands of years, groups migrated out of Africa into Asia, Europe, Australia, and eventually the Americas.

For almost all of human history, people lived as hunter-gatherers during the Paleolithic, or Old Stone Age. Small groups of related families moved with the seasons, following herds and ripening plants. They made tools of stone, bone, and wood, used fire to cook and stay warm, made clothing from hides, and painted animals on cave walls, such as the famous paintings at Lascaux, France, made about 17,000 years ago.

Need	How hunter-gatherers met it
food	hunting, fishing, gathering nuts, roots, berries
shelter	caves, huts of branches, bones, and hides
tools	stone blades and scrapers, spears, needles of bone
communication and art	spoken language, cave paintings, carvings, music

ACTIVITY · WHAT'S IN THE PACK?

What would a nomadic family carry?

You need: paper; pencil.

1. Your band of 25 is moving to its winter camp. Everything must be carried.
2. List the 8 most important items you would take and why.
3. Compare your list with a family member's and agree on a final list.

Record: your final list with a reason for each item.

KEY IDEA

For most of human history, people were nomadic hunter-gatherers who used stone tools and fire and spread from Africa across the world.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. Where did Homo sapiens first appear?

Answer: Africa

2. Why did hunter-gatherers move often?

Answer: to follow herds and seasonal plants

3. Name one Paleolithic technology.

Answer: stone tools, fire, bone needles, spears

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.2.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.2

#	Question	Answer
1	Old Stone Age	Paleolithic
2	A person who moves from place to place	nomad
3	Why did groups stay small?	An area could only feed a small group; easier to move.
4	What do cave paintings suggest about early people?	They had art, beliefs, and close knowledge of animals.
5	How did fire change life?	warmth, cooking, protection, light
6	Explain why archaeologists know more about Paleolithic tools than Paleolithic clothing.	Stone tools survive for thousands of years; hides and plant fibers usually rot away.
7	Describe one advantage and one challenge of the hunter-gatherer way of life.	Advantage: varied diet, freedom to move. Challenge: food could be scarce; constant travel.

WEEKLY CHECK · Fri Oct 30

Weekly Check 1: Historians and Early Humans — Answer Key

Answers

#	Question	Answer
1	Primary or secondary: a photo taken in 1920	primary
2	Primary or secondary: an encyclopedia article	secondary
3	Which is earlier: 1500 BCE or 900 BCE?	1500 BCE
4	Years between 300 BCE and 200 CE	499
5	Where did Homo sapiens first appear?	Africa
6	Why did hunter-gatherers move from place to place?	to follow animals and seasonal plants for food

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.3 · C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8 · Tue Nov 3

Lesson 1.3: The Agricultural Revolution

I can explain how farming began and how it changed human life.

Objective	Students analyze the Agricultural Revolution.
Standard	C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8 — Analyze change and continuity; human–environment interaction.
Date	Tue Nov 3
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Workbook Lesson 1.3
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	Move or stay?
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson; study the map.
Analyze	10	Discuss before/after chart; costs of farming.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook lesson pages: Warm-Up through Exit Ticket.
Exit Ticket	3	Student completes the Exit Ticket alone. Check it before the next lesson.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Thinking farming happened suddenly everywhere.

SUPPORT

- Before/after picture cards.

EXTEND

- Sprout wheat or barley seeds in a cup.

STUDENT LESSON 1.3 · WITH ANSWERS

Lesson 1.3: The Agricultural Revolution

THINK ABOUT IT

Would you rather move every season to find food, or stay in one place and grow it? What would you gain and lose?

Beginning around 10,000 BCE in the Fertile Crescent of Southwest Asia, people began planting wild wheat and barley and herding goats and sheep. This change, called the Agricultural Revolution, took thousands of years. Farming also began on its own in other places: rice and millet in China, corn in Mexico, potatoes in South America.

Early farming villages in the Fertile Crescent



Before farming	After farming
nomadic	settled villages
small bands	larger populations
food found or hunted	food grown and stored; surplus
few possessions	houses, pottery, tools for farming
most people did the same work	some people specialized in other jobs

Farming brought problems too. People worked long hours, ate fewer kinds of food, and could starve if crops failed. Living close together and near animals spread disease. Still, food surplus allowed populations to grow and set the stage for cities.

ACTIVITY · GAINS AND LOSSES

Was farming an improvement?

You need: paper.

1 Make a T-chart: Gains | Losses.

2 List at least four of each from the lesson.

3 Decide: for an ordinary person, was life better or worse? Write a claim with two pieces of evidence.

Record: your T-chart and claim.

KEY IDEA

Domesticating plants and animals let people settle, grow surpluses, and build larger communities, with new benefits and new problems.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. Where did farming first begin?

Answer: the Fertile Crescent (Southwest Asia)

2. What is a surplus?

Answer: more than is needed

3. Name one problem farming created.

Answer: e.g. disease, harder work, crop failure

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.3.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.3

#	Question	Answer
1	New Stone Age	Neolithic
2	Taming plants and animals	domestication
3	Two crops first domesticated in the Fertile Crescent	wheat and barley
4	A crop first domesticated in Mexico	corn (maize)
5	Why did farming lead to settled villages?	Farmers had to stay near their fields.
6	How did surplus lead to new jobs?	Not everyone had to farm, so some could specialize.

#	Question	Answer
7	Write a claim: Was the Agricultural Revolution good for humans? Support it with two pieces of evidence.	Answers vary; must use evidence from both lists.
8	Why do historians call farming a “revolution” even though it took thousands of years?	It completely changed how humans lived.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.4 · C3 D2.His.1.6-8 · Thu Nov 5

Lesson 1.4: From Villages to Civilizations

I can identify the features of a civilization and explain how surplus led to cities.

Objective	Students identify the features of civilization.
Standard	C3 D2.His.1.6-8 — Analyze connections among events and developments.
Date	Thu Nov 5
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Dried beans, role cards, workbook Lesson 1.4
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	City vs village.
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson.
Analyze	10	Discuss features chart; flow chart.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook. Weekly Check Friday.
Exit Ticket	3	Student completes the Exit Ticket alone. Check it before the next lesson.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Thinking “civilized” means “better.”

SUPPORT

- Features checklist.

EXTEND

- Research how Çatalhöyük was excavated.

STUDENT LESSON 1.4 · WITH ANSWERS

Lesson 1.4: From Villages to Civilizations

THINK ABOUT IT

What makes a city different from a village?

Some farming villages grew into towns. Jericho, near the Jordan River, had a stone wall and tower by about 8000 BCE. Çatalhöyük in Anatolia (modern Turkey) was home to thousands of people around 7000 BCE; its houses were built so close together that people walked across the rooftops and entered through openings in the roofs.

Historians use several features to describe a civilization:

Feature	Why it appears
cities	food surplus supports many people in one place
organized government	leaders manage water, defense, and laws
specialized jobs	potters, weavers, priests, soldiers, traders
social classes	some people gain more wealth or power
religion and public buildings	temples unite people around shared beliefs
writing and record keeping	track harvests, taxes, and trade
technology and art	new tools, buildings, and crafts



ACTIVITY · VILLAGE TO CITY SIMULATION

How does a surplus change a community?

You need: 20 dried beans (grain); role cards: farmer, potter, priest, guard, trader.

1 Each farmer 'grows' 5 beans per season but needs only 3 to eat.

2 Decide how the 2 extra beans per farmer can support people with other jobs.

3 Add one more job each round as the surplus grows.

Record: how many non-farmers your surplus could support, and the new problems (who decides? who guards the beans?).

KEY IDEA

Food surplus led to larger populations, specialized jobs, and the features of civilization.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. Name three features of a civilization.

Answer: e.g. cities, government, specialized jobs, social classes, writing

2. What made specialization possible?

Answer: food surplus

3. How did people enter houses at Çatalhöyük?

Answer: through openings in the roofs

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.4.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.4

#	Question	Answer
1	A complex society with cities and writing	civilization
2	Doing one kind of job	specialization
3	Why might a growing town need a government?	to organize water, defense, and laws
4	Why did record keeping develop?	to track harvests, taxes, and trade
5	Put in order: cities, surplus, farming, specialization	farming, surplus, specialization, cities
6	Is your community a civilization by the historians' definition? Use three features as evidence.	Answers vary.
7	Explain the chain from farming to cities.	Farming → surplus → population growth → specialized jobs and trade → cities and government.

WEEKLY CHECK · Fri Nov 6

Weekly Check 2: Farming and Civilization — Answer Key

Answers

#	Question	Answer
1	Where did farming first begin?	the Fertile Crescent
2	What is a food surplus?	more food than needed
3	Name two features of a civilization.	e.g. cities, government, writing, specialized jobs
4	Name an early farming town.	Jericho or Çatalhöyük
5	Explain how a food surplus led to specialized jobs.	Not everyone had to farm, so some people could do other work.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.5 · C3 D2.Geo.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8 · Tue Nov 10

Lesson 1.5: Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers

I can explain how the geography of Mesopotamia shaped early civilization there.

Objective	Students analyze geography's effect on Mesopotamia.
Standard	C3 D2.Geo.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8 — Use maps; explain how environment influences cultural patterns.
Date	Tue Nov 10
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Pan, soil, water, craft stick, workbook Lesson 1.5
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	First cities in a dry land.
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson; study the map.
Analyze	10	Discuss challenge/solution chart.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook lesson pages: Warm-Up through Exit Ticket.
Exit Ticket	3	Student completes the Exit Ticket alone. Check it before the next lesson.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Thinking the floods were gentle and regular like the Nile's.

SUPPORT

- Challenge → solution cards.

EXTEND

- Compare with Mississippi Delta flooding and levees.

STUDENT LESSON 1.5 · WITH ANSWERS

Lesson 1.5: Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers

THINK ABOUT IT

Mesopotamia had hot, dry summers and almost no rain in the south, yet it became home to the world's first cities. How?

The Fertile Crescent



Mesopotamia lies between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers in modern Iraq. Each spring, snow melting in the northern mountains made the rivers flood, spreading rich silt over the plain. But the floods were unpredictable: some years they were too small, other years they destroyed fields and villages. Summers were hot and rainfall was low.

Farmers solved these problems by working together. They dug irrigation canals to carry river water to fields, built levees to hold back floods, and stored water for dry months. Organizing these big projects required leaders and laws. The region had few trees and little stone, so people built with sun-dried mud bricks and traded grain and cloth for wood, stone, and metal.

Geographic challenge	Human solution
unpredictable floods	levees and drainage ditches
little rain in summer	irrigation canals and storage basins
few trees or stone	mud bricks; trade for resources
flat land, open to invaders	city walls and armies

ACTIVITY · IRRIGATION MODEL

How can canals bring water to fields?

You need: a baking pan with soil or sand; a cup of water; a craft stick.

1 Shape a "river" along one side of the pan.

2 Use the stick to carve canals from the river to three "fields."

3 Pour water into the river at the high end. Where does it go?

4 Add a small dirt bank (levee) and test it again.

Record: a labeled sketch of your irrigation system and what worked.

KEY IDEA

Mesopotamia's rivers gave rich soil and water, but floods and dry summers forced people to cooperate on irrigation and levees.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. What does "Mesopotamia" mean?

Answer: land between the rivers

2. Name the two rivers.

Answer: Tigris and Euphrates

3. Why did Mesopotamians build with mud brick?

Answer: There were few trees and little stone.

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.5.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.5

#	Question	Answer
1	Rich soil left by floods	silt
2	Bringing water to crops	irrigation
3	Use the map. Which body of water do the Tigris and Euphrates flow into? (figure)	the Persian Gulf

#	Question	Answer
4	In which modern country is most of Mesopotamia?	Iraq
5	Which city on the map is farthest south?	Ur
6	Explain how a geographic challenge led to cooperation and government.	Unpredictable floods and dry summers required large irrigation and levee projects that needed leaders and rules.
7	Were the rivers more helpful or harmful to Mesopotamians? Explain.	Answers vary; rich soil and water vs destructive floods.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.6 · C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Civ.6.6-8 · Thu Nov 12

Lesson 1.6: Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society

I can describe Sumerian city-states, religion, and social classes.

Objective	Students describe Sumerian society.
Standard	C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Civ.6.6-8 — Analyze connections; describe government and social structure.
Date	Thu Nov 12
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Blocks or sugar cubes, workbook Lesson 1.6
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	Town with its own king.
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson.
Analyze	10	Discuss social pyramid; religion and power.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook. Weekly Check Friday.
Exit Ticket	3	Student completes the Exit Ticket alone. Check it before the next lesson.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Assuming all ancient women had no rights.

SUPPORT

- Social pyramid diagram.

EXTEND

- Research the Royal Tombs of Ur.

STUDENT LESSON 1.6 · WITH ANSWERS

Lesson 1.6: Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society

THINK ABOUT IT

If your town had its own king, army, and gods, how would you feel about the next town over?

By about 3500 BCE, the people of Sumer, in southern Mesopotamia, had built some of the world's first cities, including Ur and Uruk. Each was a city-state with its own ruler, army, and patron god. City-states often fought over water and land.

Sumerians practiced polytheism. They believed gods controlled nature and that people must serve them. At the center of each city stood a ziggurat, a huge stepped tower of mud brick with a temple on top. Priests were powerful, and at first they helped manage the city's grain. Over time, war leaders became kings, who claimed to rule with the gods' approval.

Social class	Who
upper class	kings, priests, and nobles
middle class	merchants, artisans, scribes, farmers who owned land
lower class	farm workers and laborers
enslaved people	often prisoners of war or people in debt

Women in Sumer could own property and run businesses, and some were priestesses, but most power belonged to men.

ACTIVITY · DESIGN A ZIGGURAT

What did a ziggurat show about Sumerian values?

You need: sugar cubes or building blocks; paper.

1. Build a three-level stepped tower with a shrine on top.
2. Add a ramp or stairway.
3. Write two sentences explaining why the temple was the tallest building in the city.

Record: a sketch and your explanation.

KEY IDEA

Sumer was made of independent city-states centered on ziggurats, ruled by kings and priests, with clear social classes.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. Name two Sumerian city-states.

Answer: Ur and Uruk (also Lagash, Kish)

2. What was a ziggurat?

Answer: a stepped temple tower

3. Why did city-states fight?

Answer: over water and land

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.6.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.6

#	Question	Answer
1	Belief in many gods	polytheism
2	A city with its own government	city-state
3	Who was at the top of Sumerian society?	kings, priests, nobles
4	Name one right Sumerian women had.	own property, run businesses
5	Why were scribes respected?	Few people could read and write.
6	What does the location and size of the ziggurat suggest about the role of religion in Sumer?	Religion was central and powerful; the temple dominated the city.
7	Compare a Sumerian city-state with a modern U.S. city.	Answers vary; e.g. both have government and jobs; Sumer had kings, its own army, and patron gods.

WEEKLY CHECK · Fri Nov 13

Weekly Check 3: Mesopotamia and Sumer — Answer Key

Answers

#	Question	Answer
1	The two rivers of Mesopotamia	Tigris and Euphrates
2	Bringing water to crops through canals	irrigation
3	A stepped temple tower	ziggurat
4	Belief in many gods	polytheism
5	Describe one geographic challenge in Mesopotamia and how people solved it.	e.g. unpredictable floods → levees; dry summers → irrigation canals.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.7 · C3 D2.His.1.6-8 · Tue Nov 17

Lesson 1.7: Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing

I can explain how and why writing developed in Sumer and how it changed society.

Objective	Students explain the development of writing.
Standard	C3 D2.His.1.6-8 — Analyze connections among developments.
Date	Tue Nov 17
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Clay, craft sticks, workbook Lesson 1.7
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	No writing.
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson.
Analyze	10	Discuss stages of writing; Gilgamesh summary.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook lesson pages: Warm-Up through Exit Ticket.
Exit Ticket	3	Student completes the Exit Ticket alone. Check it before the next lesson.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Thinking writing was invented for stories first.

SUPPORT

- Picture → symbol chart.

EXTEND

- Look up your name in a cuneiform chart.

STUDENT LESSON 1.7 · WITH ANSWERS

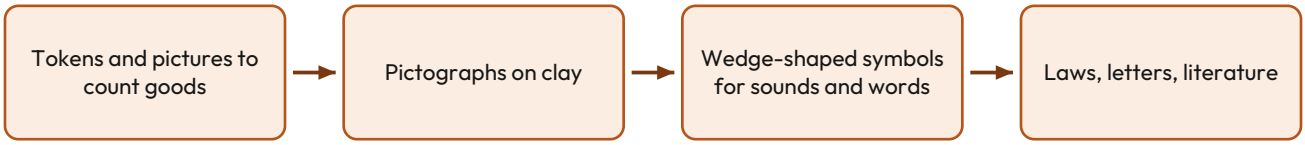
Lesson 1.7: Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing

THINK ABOUT IT

How would your life change if nothing could be written down?

Around 3200 BCE, Sumerians in cities like Uruk began keeping records on clay tablets. At first they drew small pictures to count grain, sheep, and taxes. Over time the pictures became wedge-shaped marks pressed with a reed stylus: cuneiform, from the Latin word for "wedge." Cuneiform was used for more than 3,000 years and for many languages.

Writing was hard to learn, so scribes trained for years in schools. They wrote contracts, laws, letters, medical texts, prayers, and literature, including the Epic of Gilgamesh, one of the oldest stories in the world. It tells of Gilgamesh, a king of Uruk, who searches for the secret of living forever and learns that every human life must end.



Other Sumerian innovations include the wheel (used for pottery and carts), the plow, sailboats, and a number system based on 60, which is why we still have 60 minutes in an hour and 360 degrees in a circle.

ACTIVITY · CLAY TABLET SCRIBE

What was it like to write in cuneiform?

You need: air-dry clay or play dough; a craft stick cut to a wedge point or a chopstick.

1. Flatten the clay into a tablet.
2. Press wedge shapes to record a "receipt": 5 sheep and 3 jars of barley (invent symbols).
3. Trade tablets with a partner and try to read each other's record.

Record: your symbol key and two problems a scribe would face.

KEY IDEA

Writing began as record keeping, became cuneiform, and let people keep laws, history, and literature.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. What was cuneiform first used for?

Answer: keeping records of goods, trade, and taxes

2. What does cuneiform mean?

Answer: wedge-shaped

3. Who was Gilgamesh?

Answer: a king of Uruk, hero of the epic

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.7.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.7

#	Question	Answer
1	Tool used to write on clay	stylus
2	A long poem about a hero	epic
3	About when did writing begin in Sumer?	about 3200 BCE
4	Why did scribes train for years?	Cuneiform had hundreds of signs and was hard to learn.
5	Name a Sumerian idea we still use.	60 minutes in an hour / 360 degrees in a circle / the wheel
6	Explain how writing helped governments become more powerful.	Rulers could record taxes, laws, and property, and send orders across distances.
7	Which Sumerian invention do you think was most important? Defend your choice.	Answers vary.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.8 · C3 D2.Civ.3.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8 · Thu Nov 19

Lesson 1.8: Empires and the Code of Hammurabi

I can describe the first empires and analyze Hammurabi's Code as a primary source.

Objective	Students analyze the first empires and Hammurabi's Code.
Standard	C3 D2.Civ.3.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8 — Examine the origins, purposes, and impact of laws; analyze primary sources.
Date	Thu Nov 19
Time	About 50 minutes
Materials	Highlighters, workbook Lesson 1.8, Unit 1 Review
Get ready	Read the student lesson and its sources, preview the maps, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions.

Lesson Flow

Part	Min	What to do and say
Warm-Up	5	Written laws.
Read and Discuss	15	Read the lesson. Read the source excerpt aloud.
Analyze	10	Model source analysis.
Guided Practice	7	Check Your Understanding 1–3.
Independent	10	Workbook; then the Unit 1 Review.
Exit Ticket	3	Tomorrow (Friday): Unit 1 Test.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

- Judging ancient law only by modern values without context.

SUPPORT

- Source-analysis questions: who, when, why, what's missing?

EXTEND

- Write a fair code of five family rules.

STUDENT LESSON 1.8 · WITH ANSWERS

Lesson 1.8: Empires and the Code of Hammurabi

THINK ABOUT IT

Why might it matter that laws are written down for everyone to see?

Around 2334 BCE, Sargon of Akkad conquered the Sumerian city-states and created what many historians call the world's first empire. Later, Hammurabi, king of Babylon (ruled about 1792–1750 BCE), united much of Mesopotamia. About 1754 BCE he had 282 laws carved on a tall stone stele for public display. The stele is now in the Louvre museum in Paris.

PRIMARY SOURCE

From the Code of Hammurabi

Babylon, about 1754 BCE. Translated by L. W. King (1910). Public domain.

196. If a man put out the eye of another man, his eye shall be put out.

198. If he put out the eye of a freed man, or break the bone of a freed man, he shall pay one gold mina.

199. If he put out the eye of a man's slave, or break the bone of a man's slave, he shall pay one-half of its value.

229. If a builder build a house for some one, and does not construct it properly, and the house which he built fall in and kill its owner, then that builder shall be put to death.

LOOK CLOSER · ANALYZE A PRIMARY SOURCE

What do Laws 196, 198, and 199 reveal about Babylonian society?

1. Law 196: harming another man means the same harm in return (“an eye for an eye”).
2. Law 198: harming a freed man means paying a fine (one gold mina) instead.
3. Law 199: harming an enslaved person means paying the owner.

Answer: Punishments depended on social class, so Babylonian law treated people unequally; laws protected property and order more than equal rights.

Hammurabi's Code was not the first law code, but it is one of the best preserved. By writing laws in public, he showed that rules applied across his empire, and he claimed the gods gave him authority to rule justly.

ACTIVITY · FAIR OR UNFAIR?

Do these laws match our ideas of justice?

You need: the source excerpt; highlighters.

1 Highlight each punishment.

2 Rate each law from 1 (very unfair) to 5 (very fair) by today's standards.

3 Find one idea in the code that is similar to modern law (for example, builders responsible for safe buildings).

Record: your ratings and a paragraph comparing Hammurabi's Code with modern laws.

KEY IDEA

Sargon built the first empire; Hammurabi's written code brought order but punished people differently by class.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answers are shown in red.

1. Who created the first empire?

Answer: Sargon of Akkad

2. About when was Hammurabi's Code written?

Answer: about 1754 BCE

3. Did the code treat all people equally?

Answer: No; punishments depended on social class.

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.8.

Workbook Answer Key · Lesson 1.8

#	Question	Answer
1	Many lands ruled by one government	empire
2	A tall carved stone slab	stele
3	What happens to a builder whose house collapses and kills the owner?	The builder is put to death.
4	What is the punishment for putting out a freed man's eye?	paying one gold mina
5	Why would Hammurabi carve his laws in stone in a public place?	So everyone knew the laws and they couldn't easily be changed; to show his authority.
6	Name one way the code is like modern law and one way it is different.	Like: builders responsible for safety. Different: unequal punishments by class; harsh physical punishments.
7	Why was writing laws down an important step for civilization?	Written laws were public, consistent, and harder for rulers to change at will.

UNIT REVIEW · Thu Nov 19 (homework) or as needed

Unit 1 Review — Answer Key

Homework or a study session before the test.

Answers

#	Question	Answer
1	artifact	object made by people in the past
2	domestication	taming plants and animals
3	city-state	a city with its own government
4	cuneiform	wedge-shaped writing
5	empire	many lands under one government
6	surplus	more than needed
7	Explain how geography, farming, and writing each helped Sumer become a civilization.	Rivers gave water and soil; farming gave surplus; writing allowed records and laws.

UNIT TEST · Fri Nov 20

Unit 1 Test — Answer Key

Answers

#	Question	Answer
1	Primary or secondary: a clay tablet from Ur	primary
2	Primary or secondary: a documentary about Sumer	secondary
3	Order from earliest: 1754 BCE, 3200 BCE, 2334 BCE	3200 BCE, 2334 BCE, 1754 BCE
4	How many years from 2000 BCE to 1500 BCE?	500
5	How did most Paleolithic people get food? A. farming B. trading in cities C. hunting and gathering D. fishing fleets	C. hunting and gathering
6	What is domestication?	taming plants and animals for human use
7	Name one benefit and one problem of farming.	e.g. surplus / disease or harder work
8	Which came first? A. cities B. food surplus C. writing	B. food surplus
9	Use the map. Which labeled city is farthest south, closest to the Persian Gulf? (figure)	Ur
10	Why did Mesopotamians need irrigation?	Little rain in summer; needed to bring river water to crops.
11	What was a ziggurat?	a stepped temple tower
12	What was cuneiform first used for?	keeping records (goods, taxes, trade)
13	Who created the first empire?	Sargon of Akkad
14	Reread the excerpt from Hammurabi's Code. What does it show about justice and social class in Babylon? Use two laws as evidence.	Rubric: claim that punishments depended on class (1); two laws cited accurately (1); explanation of what this reveals (1).
15	Explain how the geography of Mesopotamia led to the development of government and laws.	Rubric: describes the rivers/floods/dry climate (1); explains irrigation and levee projects (1); connects cooperation to leaders and government (1); connects government to written laws (1).

Scoring

Score	What it means / next step
17–20 (85%+)	Mastered.
14–16	Proficient; review missed skills.
Below 14	Reteach and retest.

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